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Mumford & Sons x Hozier: The unexpected collaboration we didn't know we needed!

Sound & Soul

Streaming in the Slow Lane: Why millions are craving deeper sounds in 2025

HOZIER

The "Soul Revivalist"

Contents

1 | LETTER FROM THE EDITOR
By Charlotte Reeves
A reflection on the return of authentic artistry — and how Hozier's quiet resurgence in 2025 reminds us what music is meant to feel like.

2 | COVER STORY: HOZIER — REDEFINING INDIE SOUL
The Irish troubadour steps back into the spotlight with poetic precision, deep emotion, and a sound that continues to defy every expectation.

3 | BETWEEN HEAVEN AND EARTH
From the smoky warmth of gospel to the restless hum of blues, explore the roots that built Hozier's unmistakable sound.

4 | INSIDE THE STUDIO
An intimate look at Hozier's creative process — the late-night writing sessions, the vintage gear, and the philosophy that drives his music.

5 | THE NEW FOLK FRONTIER
How a new wave of singer-songwriters — from Celeste to Novo Amor — are reviving the soul of folk in a digital age.

Letter from the editor.

There's a strange kind of silence that comes after a Hozier song ends. It's not emptiness — it's reflection. That rare, aching pause where you actually feel something in your chest. That's what made us put him on this month's cover. In a time when music is often measured in fifteen-second clips, Hozier's rise feels almost miraculous. He makes music for the stillness between beats — and somehow, millions are listening.

When we sat down with him in Dublin last December, the rain hadn't stopped for hours. He arrived, quiet and unhurried, guitar case slung over his shoulder like he'd just stepped out of a painting. No entourage, no flash. Just a cup of coffee, a notebook full of lyrics, and that warm, thoughtful way of speaking that makes you lean in.

He talked about faith — not in the religious sense, but faith in feeling. "I think," he said, "we've all grown afraid of sincerity." It struck me that maybe that's what he's been fighting for all along. From Take Me to Church to Francesca and now the haunting Rubber Band Man collaboration with Mumford & Sons, Hozier's music doesn't demand attention. It earns it.

And maybe that's why this moment feels so refreshing.
2024 was dominated by the algorithm — AI tracks, viral hooks, formulaic pop that burns out faster than it arrives. Then there's Hozier, standing barefoot in the storm, singing about love, death, myth, and mercy like it still matters. His rise isn't a rebellion against the machine — it's a reminder of what was lost before we built it.

So here's to the poets, the troubadours, the ones who still light candles instead of screens.
Here's to the music that lingers long after the last chord fades.
And here's to remembering that even in the age of noise, silence — when it's earned — can be the loudest thing of all.

Until next time,
Janelle Rowe
Editor-in-Chief, Rolling Stone
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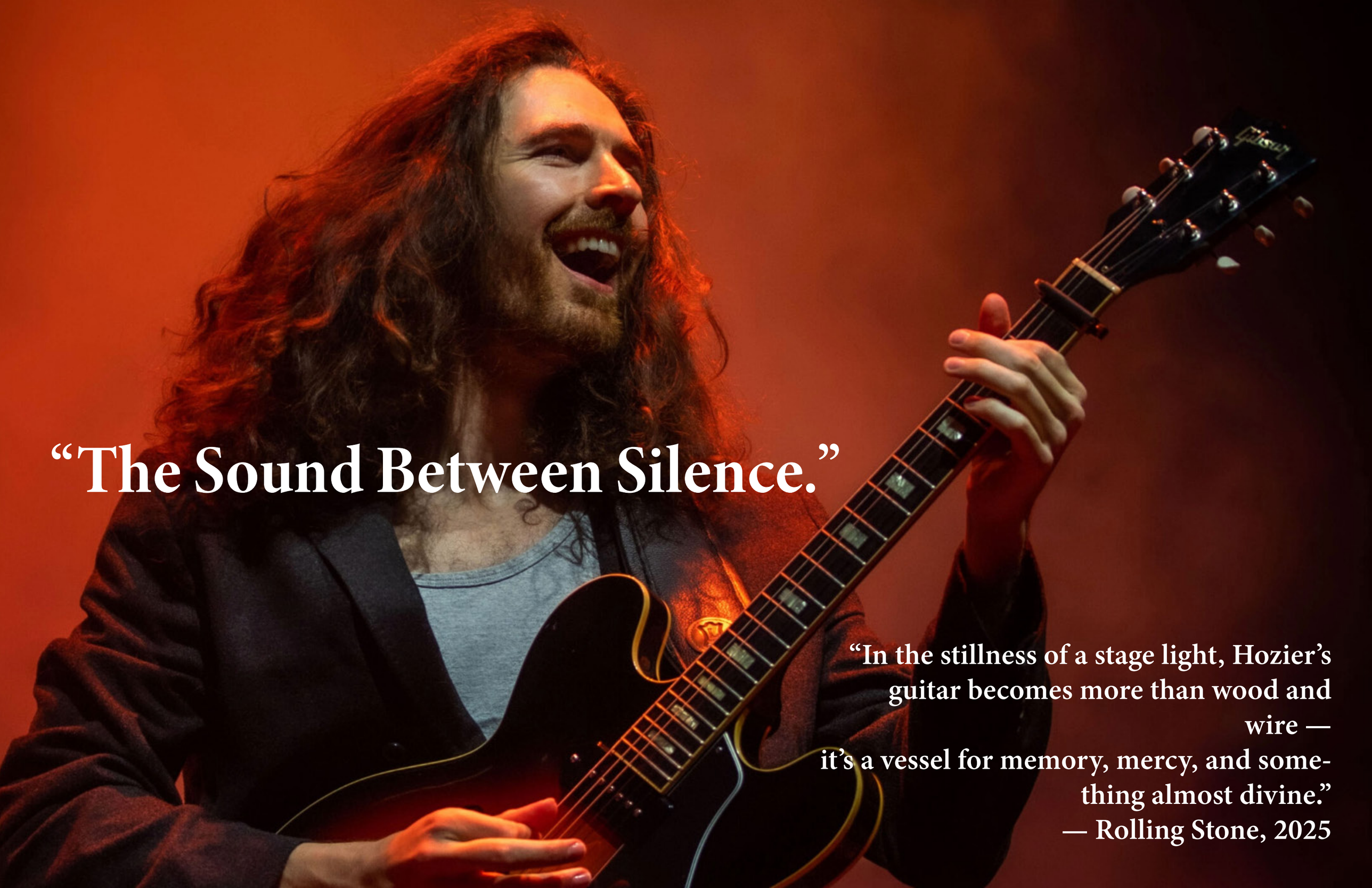

“The Sound Between Silence.”

“In the stillness of a stage light, Hozier’s guitar becomes more than wood and wire —
it’s a vessel for memory, mercy, and something almost divine.”
— Rolling Stone, 2025

REDEFINING INDIE SOUL

It's a rare thing for an artist to sound both timeless and urgent — like their music has been here forever, and yet feels designed for right now. Hozier has always existed in that space between eras, where gospel meets indie rock and poetry meets protest. But in 2024 and into 2025, something shifted. What began as the quiet fire of an Irish songwriter became a full-fledged movement — one that's rewriting what indie soul means in a digital world.

For years, Hozier was seen as an outlier — too soulful for alternative radio, too literary for pop, too introspective for the festival circuit. But his recent resurgence has proven that depth doesn't alienate; it connects. The rise of his third studio album, Unreal Unearth, alongside his 2025 collaboration with Mumford & Sons on Rubber Band Man, has turned him into an unlikely architect of a new genre wave — one that blends folk's storytelling, soul's ache, and rock's conviction into something entirely its own.

When you listen to songs like Francesca, First Light, or Unknown / Nth, you hear more than melody. You hear movement. The phrasing carries the weight of an old spiritual, the rhythm leans toward blues, and yet the production feels distinctly modern — sparse, echoing, reverent. It's indie music that believes in redemption.

Hozier's definition of soul isn't about slick grooves or retro revivalism. It's about presence. "I don't think of soul as a genre," he told Rolling Stone in December. "I think of it as a way of showing up — in your voice, in your truth, in your mistakes. It's the sound of someone meaning it."

That sincerity has become his signature. In a streaming culture obsessed with hooks and hashtags, Hozier writes for the slow listeners — those who still press play on an album and let it unfold. And audiences, weary of the algorithm, have followed. His 2024–25 tour, To Somewhere Worth Going, sold out across Europe and North America in hours, not because of hype, but because his fans see themselves in his quiet defiance.

"Every artist wants to last," he says, half-smiling. "But to last, you have to make something that can wait. I'm not chasing the moment. I'm waiting for it to come back around."

"He doesn't perform. He communicates,"

says Marucs Mumford. After a decade in music, the Irish singer-songwriter has become one of the most quietly powerful forces in modern rock. His 2024 Unreal Unearth tour sold out in under two hours — 1.2 million fans, 22 cities, and not a single pyrotechnic. . His music has always moved like weather — unpredictable, patient, quietly devastating. So when whispers began in mid-2024 that he was recording with Mumford & Sons, few knew what to make of it. The Irish poet and the British folk giants — two of the defining voices of modern folk-rock — sharing a studio? It sounded almost too mythical to be real, like a rumor dreamt up in a smoky pub somewhere along the River Liffey.

Both artists had long explored similar themes — faith, endurance, the grit beneath grace — but had never crossed paths in sound. Fans speculated wildly: would it be a folk anthem or a blues elegy? When Rubber Band Man dropped in August 2025, it proved to be something deeper — two worlds colliding, their voices binding in something raw, holy, and human, echoing like a hymn for the modern soul.

"It's about tension and resilience," Hozier says. "How we stretch but don't snap." It's a testament to his artistic evolution — still folk at heart, but larger, looser, and louder in emotion.

Both artists had long explored similar themes — faith, endurance, the grit beneath grace — yet had never truly crossed paths in sound. Fans speculated wildly: would it be a foot-stomping folk anthem or a blues-soaked elegy? When Rubber Band Man dropped in August 2025, it proved to be something far more transcendent — two worlds colliding in perfect harmony. The track unfolds like a sermon wrapped in a storm, their voices weaving through verses of doubt and devotion. It's the sound of two storytellers finding common ground — raw, holy, and deeply human — a reminder that redemption often lives in the quiet between chords.

It's hard to tell where the voice ends and the prayer begins.
Hozier sits in the back of a Dublin recording studio, headphones half-off, humming the final chorus of "Rubber Band Man." "There's always a little faith in every song," he says. "Even the sad ones."